

Accenture Design Test — Full Strategic Analysis

Prepared from the perspective of a Senior UX Hiring Manager + Principal Product Designer

Source: Design_Challenges_11-9.pptx (3 options, 2 days each)

1. Assignment Overview

Option 1 — "Sulekha": Gen Z Fashion Rental Service

Problem in plain language: Design an app/website/social/pop-up/peer-to-peer ecosystem where Gen Z users can rent, swap, or buy pre-loved clothes instead of buying fast fashion — because Gen Z cares about sustainability but still wants trendy, personalized style.

What you're actually asked to do: Build an omnichannel subscription service (not just an app) covering digital + physical touchpoints, then show a persona, a service blueprint, a journey map, key screens, and your rationale.

Hidden expectations:

- You're expected to design the *business model* implicitly (subscription tiers, rental logistics, returns/cleaning, trust between strangers exchanging clothes) even though it's not asked outright — because a "service" brief without an operating logic looks naive.
- Sustainability needs to be shown as a designed behavior (how the UI nudges reuse), not just a marketing tagline.
- Peer-to-peer exchange implies trust & safety design (ratings, verification) — most candidates miss this.

Underlying business problem: How does a fashion brand build recurring revenue and brand loyalty with a generation that resists ownership and traditional retail, while operationalizing a complex reverse-logistics problem (getting clothes back, cleaned, and re-circulated)?

Option 2 — Chronic Care Companion for Gen Z/Millennials

Problem in plain language: Young adults with chronic conditions (diabetes, PCOS, anxiety, hypertension) don't follow up with doctors and get lost in disconnected apps. Design a connected service — with AI — that keeps them engaged with their own health from hospital discharge into daily life.

What you're actually asked to do: Map a patient's journey from **discharge to daily self-care**, blend digital (apps, chatbots, wearables) with physical (home visits, clinics)

touchpoints, and specifically design how **agentic AI** coaches, detects risk, adapts to literacy level, and escalates to a human when needed. You must also show the "backstage" — clinicians, data, care teams — not just the patient-facing app.

Hidden expectations:

- This brief explicitly asks for **service design maturity** (frontstage/backstage), which most portfolios never show. You're expected to diagram this, not just describe it.
- "Agentic AI" is a deliberate buzzword test — they want to see if you can design *escalation logic and guardrails* (when AI hands off to a human), not just a chatbot UI.
- Health literacy and accessibility are implied requirements even though "accessibility" isn't a bullet point — chronic care users skew toward lower trust and higher anxiety, so tone, comprehension level, and error-recovery design matter.
- You're expected to address **behavior change theory** (motivation, trust, adherence) with some grounding — even a light nod to frameworks like habit loops or the Fogg Behavior Model signals seniority.

Underlying business problem: Reduce cost-of-care and hospital readmission by keeping patients engaged outside clinical walls, while building enough automated trust that AI can safely triage without a human in every loop — a genuine problem in Accenture's healthcare consulting practice.

Option 3 — Ace Bank: Gamified Gen Z Finance Service

Problem in plain language: Design a next-gen bank experience for Gen Z that makes managing money feel like a game (streaks, badges, challenges, community) instead of a chore — across app, web, chatbots, wearables, branches, ATMs, and human coaches.

What you're actually asked to do: Design onboarding, daily engagement (gamification), omnichannel support, AI-driven "smart nudges," and the service design connecting frontstage/backstage — while the brief's own **Tips** slide explicitly warns you not to slap on points/badges without psychological justification.

Hidden expectations:

- The brief itself flags the #1 trap ("don't just add points or badges") — so evaluators will actively look for whether you fell into it anyway. This is the most self-aware brief of the three.
- Financial gamification carries real ethical tension (dark patterns, encouraging overspending via "streaks"). A strong candidate proactively addresses **responsible gamification** and trust/compliance concerns — not stated, but implied by "Builds trust, good habits."
- AR/VR is mentioned as "if relevant" — a trap for scope creep. Over-designing AR features you can't justify signals poor judgment, not innovation.

- Regulatory/trust context (banking = high-stakes, regulated industry) is implied; a naive, purely "fun app" answer without addressing security/trust will read as shallow.

Underlying business problem: Traditional banks are losing Gen Z relevance to fintech apps; the challenge is retention and financial-habit formation as a competitive moat, monetized through deeper engagement (more products, higher balances, cross-sell) — a classic digital banking transformation problem Accenture consults on.

2. Difficulty Ranking

Rank	Assignment	Why	Est. Time	UX/UI Skill Needed	Research Load	Mistake
Easiest	Option 1 – Sulekha	Familiar domain (fashion/e-commerce), concrete and tangible touchpoints, most candidates already understand rental/resale mental models (Rent the Runway, ThredUp, Vinted)	10-14 hrs across 2 days	Mid-level — solid IA, journey mapping, UI polish	Low–Moderate (light competitive scan)	Low, but "boring/ξ risk is hi
Moderate	Option 3 – Ace Bank	Familiar consumer app category (fintech/banking apps exist everywhere) but gamification-done-right is a genuinely hard design problem, plus regulatory/trust subtext	12-16 hrs	Mid-Senior — needs psychology-informed gamification + omnichannel thinking	Moderate (behavioral design, fintech UX patterns)	Moderat easy to s "shallow gamifica trap the l warns ag
Most Difficult	Option 2 – Chronic Care	Requires healthcare domain literacy, service-design maturity (frontstage/backstage), and credible AI-escalation logic — three specialist skill sets stacked together	16-20+ hrs	Senior — service design, health UX, AI interaction design, accessibility	High — care journeys, clinical workflows, health literacy, AI governance basics	High — € get clinic ethically (unsafe , escalatio deaf hea messagi

Bottom line: Option 1 is the safest, fastest path to a competent submission. Option 3 has moderate difficulty but the highest "impress or embarrass yourself" swing based on gamification execution. Option 2 has the steepest learning curve but the highest ceiling for candidates with service-design chops.

3. What Accenture Is Actually Evaluating

Option 1 — Sulekha

Stated: persona, service blueprint, omnichannel journey map, key screens, design rationale. **Unstated:** business-model literacy (subscription economics), trust & safety design for P2P exchange, sustainability as a *designed behavior* rather than a slogan, visual craft (since fashion is a visually judged category — weak UI here is more damaging than in other briefs).

Dimension	Stated?
UX thinking	Stated
Information architecture	Stated
Visual design	Unstated but heavily judged (fashion category)
User research	Semi-stated (persona)
Service design	Stated (blueprint)
Business/product thinking	Unstated
Innovation	Unstated
AI usage	Not applicable

Option 2 — Chronic Care

Stated: persona, service blueprint, patient journey, key screens, design rationale, plus explicit "key areas" (journey, touchpoints, agentic AI, service design, behavior change). **Unstated:** health literacy/accessibility sensitivity, AI safety/escalation logic, ethical handling of vulnerable users, cross-functional systems thinking (clinician + patient + data).

Dimension	Stated?
UX thinking	Stated
Product/service thinking	Stated (explicitly, "service design")
AI usage	Stated (agentic AI)
Accessibility	Unstated but critical
Behavior change / psychology	Stated
Information architecture	Semi-stated
Innovation	Unstated but rewarded (novel AI escalation models)
Presentation/storytelling	Unstated but decisive — this is the hardest brief to explain clearly

Option 3 — Ace Bank

Stated: persona, service blueprint, patient(sic)/customer journey, key screens, rationale, plus explicit "key areas" (onboarding, daily engagement, omnichannel support, tech & rewards, service design) and a **Tips** warning against shallow gamification. **Unstated:** ethical/responsible design around financial behavior nudges, trust/security signaling in a regulated industry, restraint (not over-scoping AR/VR).

Dimension	Stated?
UX thinking	Stated
Interaction design (gamification mechanics)	Stated
Behavior change	Stated
Innovation	Stated (tech & rewards)
Design system usage	Unstated but rewarded (fintech = trust via consistent, mature UI)
Ethics / responsible design	Unstated but a key differentiator
AI usage	Stated (predictive insights, nudges)

Recommended: Option 3 — Ace Bank (Gamified Gen Z Finance), with Option 1 as the strong safe fallback if time is very limited, and Option 2 only for candidates with genuine healthcare/service-design background.

Why Option 3:

- It sits at the sweet spot of **familiar enough to execute well in 2 days, but rich enough to show range** — you can demonstrate service design, behavioral/interaction design, IA, and visual craft all in one deck without needing specialist domain knowledge (unlike healthcare).
- Banking/fintech is a category Accenture does enormous client work in — showing fluency here has direct business relevance to the interviewers' day job.
- The brief itself hands you the evaluation criteria on a plate (the "Tips" section literally tells you what NOT to do) — candidates who address that warning explicitly stand out immediately, and it's an easy win once you know to look for it.
- Gamification + trust is a genuinely interesting design tension you can showcase strategic thinking around, without needing clinical accuracy.

Why not Option 1: It's the safest but also the most commoditized — dozens of candidates will submit visually similar "sustainable fashion app" decks referencing the same competitor apps (Vinted, Rent the Runway). It's very hard to stand out here without exceptional visual craft or a genuinely novel service mechanic. Good for clearing the bar, weak for winning the interview.

Why not Option 2 (unless you have the background): Highest ceiling, but also highest floor risk. If you don't already understand basic care-journey structures, health literacy design, or how to reason about AI escalation safety, you risk producing a plausible-looking but shallow or even careless submission — in healthcare, "confidently wrong" reads worse than "honestly simple." Only choose this if you have prior healthcare, wellness, or regulated-service UX experience, or you have significant extra time to research deeply.

Best-suited candidate profile:

- **Option 1** → Generalist mid-level designers, portfolio-builders, candidates optimizing for polish and speed.
 - **Option 2** → Senior designers with service-design or healthcare/complex-systems background, or those willing to over-invest research time to prove range.
 - **Option 3** → Designers who want to show strategic + behavioral thinking without a steep domain learning curve — the best "showcase everything" choice for most candidates.
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Metric	Ranking (1 = highest)
Highest scoring potential (ceiling)	1. Option 2 (if executed well) 2. Option 3 3. Option 1
Biggest opportunity to impress	1. Option 2 (agentic AI + service design done well is rare) 2. Option 3 (nailing "responsible gamification") 3. Option 1
Biggest opportunity to fail	1. Option 2 (domain/ethics missteps) 2. Option 3 (shallow gamification trap) 3. Option 1 (generic, forgettable)
Biggest opportunity to show strategic thinking	1. Option 2 2. Option 3 3. Option 1

Interpretation: Option 2 is the highest-risk, highest-reward choice. Option 3 offers the best **risk-adjusted** upside. Option 1 is low-variance — unlikely to fail badly, unlikely to be memorable.

6. Likely Evaluation Rubric (Estimated Weightage)

Criterion	Weight	Notes
Problem understanding & framing	15%	Do you reframe the brief into a sharp problem statement/HMW?
Research quality / persona depth	10%	Grounded in real behavior, not stereotypes
Service blueprint & journey mapping	15%	Frontstage/backstage clarity, believable touchpoints
Information architecture	10%	Logical flows, navigation, edge cases
Wireframes / key screens	10%	Coverage of critical flows, not just happy path
UI quality / visual craft	10%	Consistency, hierarchy, accessibility of color/type
Design rationale ("why," not just "what")	10%	Trade-offs explicitly discussed
Innovation / differentiation	8%	Does it go beyond obvious competitor patterns?
Feasibility & business alignment	7%	Realistic for a real company to build

Criterion	Weight	Notes
Accessibility & ethics	5%	Especially decisive in Option 2 & 3
Presentation & storytelling	10%+ (multiplier)	Weak storytelling can tank a strong deck; strong storytelling can save a mediocre one

(Weights are illustrative estimates based on standard design-hiring rubrics and the brief's own emphasis — Accenture has not published an actual scorecard.)

7. Common Mistakes

Option 1 — Sulekha

- **Beginner:** Designing only the app, ignoring "omnichannel" (pop-ups, P2P, social) entirely.
- **Intermediate:** A service blueprint that's just a journey map relabeled, with no real backstage (logistics, cleaning, restocking).
- **Red flags:** No mention of trust/safety for peer exchanges; treating "sustainable" as a color palette choice instead of a behavior.
- **What seniors do:** Model the actual unit economics/logistics loop (rent → return → clean → re-list) and show how UI supports it.
- **What impresses:** A genuinely novel mechanic (e.g., a "closet karma" trust score, hyperlocal swap events) grounded in a real Gen Z insight, not decoration.

Option 2 — Chronic Care

- **Beginner:** Designing a generic health-tracking app with no service design, ignoring "frontstage/backstage."
- **Intermediate:** AI feature described as "the app uses AI to help" with no logic for escalation, error handling, or literacy adaptation.
- **Red flags:** No safeguards for AI misdiagnosis/false reassurance; tone that reads clinical/cold for an anxious user; ignoring low-literacy or low-trust segments.
- **What seniors do:** Draw an explicit AI decision/escalation flow (when AI acts, when it defers to a human), and show how backstage care-team workflows connect to the patient experience.
- **What impresses:** Addressing the tension between automation and trust directly — showing where you'd deliberately limit AI autonomy.

Option 3 — Ace Bank

- **Beginner:** Points and badges bolted onto a standard banking app with no behavioral rationale (the exact trap the brief calls out).

- **Intermediate:** Gamification that could encourage bad financial behavior (streak pressure → overspending) without acknowledging the ethical tension.
 - **Red flags:** Scope creep into unjustified AR/VR features; ignoring trust/security signaling entirely in a regulated category.
 - **What seniors do:** Tie every gamified element to a specific behavior-change mechanism (e.g., loss aversion for savings streaks, social proof for community leaderboards) and explain the "why."
 - **What impresses:** A explicit point of view on **responsible gamification** — showing where you'd intentionally *not* gamify (e.g., no streak pressure around debt repayment).
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8. Winning Strategy (Step-by-Step, applies to whichever you choose — Option 3 used as example)

1. **Reframe the brief (Day 1, Hour 1):** Write your own sharp problem statement / "How Might We," don't just restate the brief.
2. **Light research (2-3 hrs):** 3-5 competitor benchmarks (for Option 3: Cred, Fi Money, Monzo, Chime), 1-2 relevant behavior-change frameworks (Hooked model, Fogg Behavior Model), quick Gen Z financial-behavior stats — cite conceptually, don't quote verbatim.
3. **Persona (1 hr):** One sharp, specific persona beats three generic ones. Ground motivations and frustrations in the research.
4. **Service blueprint (2-3 hrs):** Explicit frontstage (user actions/touchpoints) and backstage (systems, AI, human coaches, data) rows/lanes — this is the single most differentiating deliverable across all three options.
5. **Journey map (2 hrs):** Show emotional highs/lows across onboarding → daily use → a slip-up/recovery moment (recovery moments show maturity).
6. **Key screens (4-5 hrs):** 6-10 high-fidelity screens covering: onboarding, one gamified core flow, an AI/nudge moment, and a support/escalation moment — not just the "pretty happy path."
7. **Design rationale (1-2 hrs):** For each key decision, one line: "I did X because Y, and rejected Z because [trade-off]." This single habit signals seniority more than anything else.
8. **Presentation structure:** Problem → Insight → Design principles (2-3, e.g., "Progress over Perfection," "Nudge, Don't Nag") → Solution walkthrough → Rationale/trade-offs → What I'd test next.
9. **Storytelling:** Open with a human moment (a day in the persona's life), not a feature list. Close with humility — name 1-2 things you'd validate with real users, which shows self-awareness over false confidence.
10. **Final QA:** Remove anything you can't defend in 30 seconds if asked "why?" — panels probe rationale, not decoration.

(This structure adapts directly to Options 1 and 2 — swap the domain research and backstage specifics accordingly.)

9. Effort vs Reward Analysis

Factor	Option 1 - Sulekha	Option 2 - Chronic Care	Option 3 - Ace Bank
Time investment	Low-Med	High	Medium
Difficulty	Low	High	Medium
Creativity potential	Medium	High	High
UX depth required	Medium	Very High	High
UI effort	High (visual category)	Medium	Medium-High
Research effort	Low	Very High	Medium
Presentation effort	Medium	High	Medium-High
Chance of standing out	Low	High (if done well)	High
Overall recommendation score (/10)	6.5	7.5 (high variance)	8.5

10. Final Recommendation

"If your reputation depended on my clearing this interview, I'd tell you to choose Option 3 — Ace Bank."

Confidence score: 78% (high confidence it's the best *risk-adjusted* choice for most candidates; would rise to 85%+ if you confirm you have no healthcare/service-design background, or drop to ~60% in favor of Option 2 if you do have that background and want maximum ceiling.)

Top 5 reasons:

1. It rewards strategic and behavioral design thinking without requiring specialist domain expertise you'd need to fake or rush.
2. The brief's own "Tips" slide telegraphs exactly what evaluators will penalize — an unusually clear signal you can design directly against.

3. Fintech/banking is directly relevant to Accenture's core client base, so strong work here has visible business relevance to the panel.
4. It offers the richest opportunity to demonstrate the full toolkit (service blueprint, journey map, IA, UI craft, interaction design) within a realistic 2-day window.
5. It has genuine room for a distinctive point of view (responsible gamification, trust-building) that's still achievable without deep domain research — a rare combination of differentiation potential and feasibility.

Biggest risks:

- Falling into the "points and badges" trap the brief explicitly warns against.
- Over-scoping into AR/VR or too many features instead of depth on fewer, well-justified ones.
- Skipping the "backstage"/service-design layer and turning it into a plain app case study.

How to maximize your chances:

- Anchor everything in 2–3 named design principles you invented (not generic "user-centered design" language).
 - For every gamified element, be ready to say the specific behavioral mechanism it triggers.
 - Explicitly show where you'd *restrain* gamification or tech for trust/ethical reasons — this single move differentiates you from 90% of candidates who only show what they added, never what they deliberately left out.
 - Rehearse your presentation narrative out loud — panels remember stories, not screens.
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Clarifying Questions Before You Commit

To sharpen this recommendation further, it would help to know:

1. **Your background:** Do you have prior experience in healthcare/service design, or in fintech/behavioral design? This meaningfully shifts the Option 2 vs. Option 3 calculus.
2. **Tooling & time reality:** Is the "2 days" literal, and do you have Figma/prototyping fluency, or would you need to lean more on static wireframes/slides?
3. **What "the interview" actually weighs:** Is this a portfolio round only, or will there be a live walkthrough/defense afterward? That changes how much to invest in presentation polish vs. depth of artifacts.